Lecture : 7

Global Commercial and Cultural Exchanges in the Medieval Indian Ocean World

From Baghdad to Canton

Key sources: Marco Polo • Akhbar al-Sin wa'l-Hind • The Book of the Marvels of India • Ibn Battuta • Tome Pires

Prof. Jayati Bhattacharya
Email: iimkjayati@gmail.com

The Big Argument

The Indian Ocean was one of the clearest examples of premodern globalization.

KEY POINTS

- **The Indian Ocean was a major arena of premodern globalisation** — *A dense system of interregional exchange linking many societies over long distances.*
- **Trade moved goods, people, beliefs, and institutions** — *Merchants, sailors, pilgrims, diplomats, technologies and stories all travelled together.*
- **Exchange depended on ports, monsoons, merchant networks, and law** — *These interconnected elements made large-scale, reliable exchange possible.*
- **India occupied a strategic middle position** — *Geographically central, commercially productive, and culturally influential.*

WHY IT MATTERS

This is not modern capitalism, but a dense, interregional system — India served as both a destination and a relay zone between western and eastern Asia.

Why the Indian Ocean Matters

A patterned, durable trading system — not an occasional or accidental network.

KEY POINTS

- **Connected East Africa, the Middle East, India, Southeast Asia, and China —** *An enormous arc of territory stretching from the Red Sea to the South China coast.*

- **Supported high-value and bulk trade —** *Spices and silk get remembered, but textiles, grain, horses, metals and timber mattered just as much.*

- **Functioned before European naval control —** *Challenges the idea that global integration began only when Europeans connected the world.*

- **Created durable zones of contact and exchange —** *Long-term, patterned relationships — not one-off encounters — defined the system.*

READING CONNECTION

Bernstein shows a sophisticated transregional order already existed — a key challenge to older Eurocentric narratives.

THE INDIAN OCEAN NETWORK

Medieval World (c. 8th–15th Century)

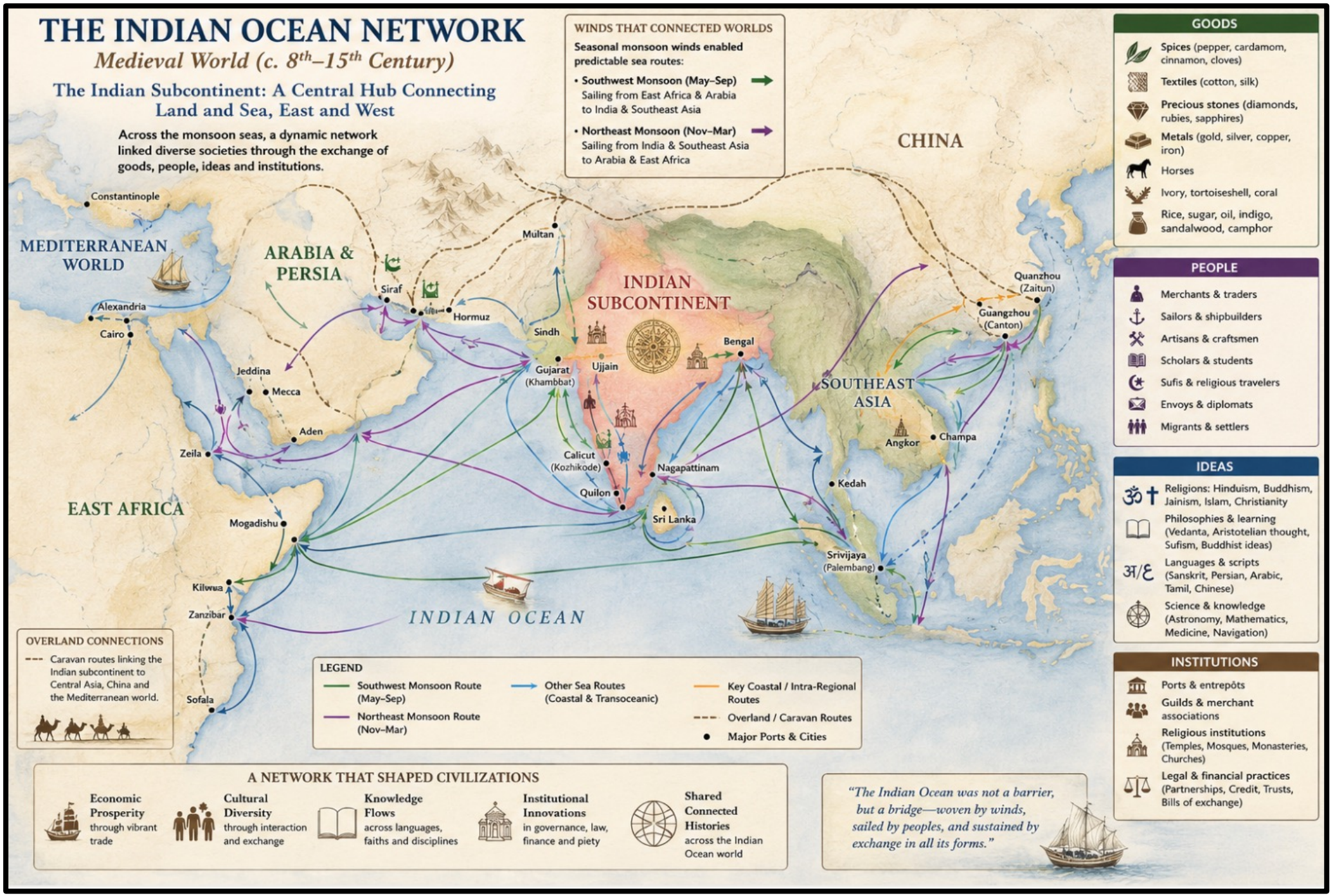
The Indian Subcontinent: A Central Hub Connecting Land and Sea, East and West

Across the monsoon seas, a dynamic network linked diverse societies through the exchange of goods, people, ideas and institutions.

WINDS THAT CONNECTED WORLDS

Seasonal monsoon winds enabled predictable sea routes:

- **Southwest Monsoon (May–Sep)** Sailing from East Africa & Arabia to India & Southeast Asia
- **Northeast Monsoon (Nov–Mar)** Sailing from India & Southeast Asia to Arabia & East Africa



OVERLAND CONNECTIONS

Caravan routes linking the Indian subcontinent to Central Asia, China and the Mediterranean world.

LEGEND

- Southwest Monsoon Route (May–Sep)
- Northeast Monsoon Route (Nov–Mar)
- Other Sea Routes (Coastal & Transoceanic)
- Key Coastal / Intra-Regional Routes
- Overland / Caravan Routes
- Major Ports & Cities

GOODS

- **Spices** (pepper, cardamom, cinnamon, cloves)
- **Textiles** (cotton, silk)
- **Precious stones** (diamonds, rubies, sapphires)
- **Metals** (gold, silver, copper, iron)
- Horses
- Ivory, tortoiseshell, coral
- Rice, sugar, oil, indigo, sandalwood, camphor

PEOPLE

- Merchants & traders
- Sailors & shipbuilders
- Artisans & craftsmen
- Scholars & students
- Sufis & religious travelers
- Envoys & diplomats
- Migrants & settlers

IDEAS

- Religions: Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, Islam, Christianity
- Philosophies & learning (Vedanta, Aristotelian thought, Sufism, Buddhist ideas)
- Languages & scripts (Sanskrit, Persian, Arabic, Tamil, Chinese)
- Science & knowledge (Astronomy, Mathematics, Medicine, Navigation)

INSTITUTIONS

- Ports & entrepôts
- Guilds & merchant associations
- Religious institutions (Temples, Mosques, Monasteries, Churches)
- Legal & financial practices (Partnerships, Credit, Trusts, Bills of exchange)

A NETWORK THAT SHAPED CIVILIZATIONS

- **Economic Prosperity** through vibrant trade
- **Cultural Diversity** through interaction and exchange
- **Knowledge Flows** across languages, faiths and disciplines
- **Institutional Innovations** in governance, law, finance and piety
- **Shared Connected Histories** across the Indian Ocean world

"The Indian Ocean was not a barrier, but a bridge—woven by winds, sailed by peoples, and sustained by exchange in all its forms."

What Moved Across the System

Global exchange rested on far more than commodities alone.

KEY POINTS

- **Goods —** *Silk, spices, porcelain, cotton textiles, horses, ivory, incense and gold — each region supplied what others lacked.*
- **People —** *Merchants, sailors, pilgrims, judges and envoys carried information and expertise alongside cargo.*
- **Ideas —** *Religion, law, stories, customs and technologies spread through the same networks — especially Islam.*
- **Institutions —** *Taxation, port regulation, contracts and credit systems made distant trust possible.*

KEY IDEA

Trade rested on both material and cultural foundations — goods alone cannot explain how the system worked.



https://www.freeman-pedia.com/exchange-in-the-indian-ocean-networks-of-exchange

Monsoons and Maritime Rhythm

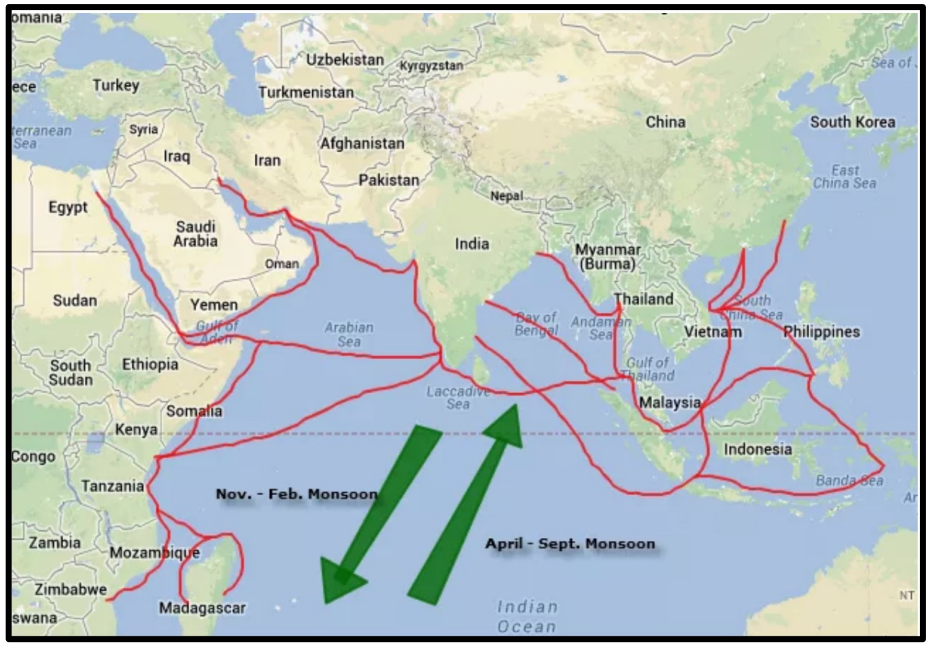
Nature itself organized the rhythm and structure of trade.

- **Seasonal winds structured trade routes —** *Ships could only cross large stretches of ocean safely at specific times of year.*

- **Sailing calendars shaped commercial timing —** *Merchants planned departures and returns around predictable wind reversals.*

- **Most merchants traveled in segments, not whole routes —** *Traders specialized in one leg, passing goods along the chain to the next.*

- **Geography and climate organised exchange —** *The Indian Ocean world was ecological as much as it was commercial.*



POINT TO CONSIDER

Nature did not just form the background — it actively shaped how and when exchange could happen.

Danger, Distance, and Uncertainty

Risk was built into the profits of long-distance trade.

KEY POINTS

- **Navigation was difficult before modern instruments —** *Sailors relied on stars, weather, experience and seasonal timing.*

- **Shipwreck, piracy, storms, and delay were constant threats —** *A journey that looked short on paper could stretch over a year in practice.*

- **Long-distance trade was profitable precisely because it was risky —** *Scarcity and danger drove up the value of whatever survived the journey.*

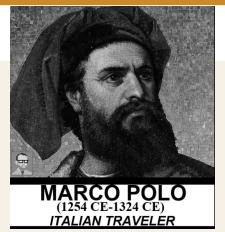
- **Travel narratives reflect both fear and fascination —** *Wonder and exaggeration are evidence of how travellers experienced distance and difference.*

READING CONNECTION

This helps us read travel literature more carefully — exaggeration is not just a flaw; it becomes evidence of travel experience.

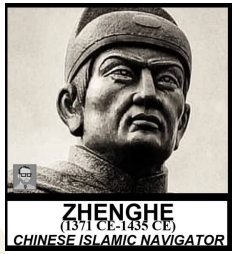
Reading the Sources

Every travel account is a socially located point of view — not a transparent window onto the past.



Marco Polo

A famous European perspective, though not always rich in technical economic detail.



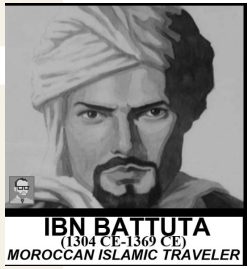
Akhbar al-Sin wa'l-Hind

An early Islamic account of the route from Baghdad to China via India written over two different centuries by a merchant and geographer

The Book of the Marvels of India

Mixes maritime reality with startling fantasy — wonder alongside observation.

*Attributed to **Buzurg ibn Shahriyar of Ramhormuz**, a ship captain and merchant from Persia, Kitāb ʻAjāʼib al-Hind was a 10th century CE writing*



Ibn Battuta and Tome Pires

A 14th-century Muslim legal and courtly view, and a 16th-century observer writing near the Portuguese arrival.



Tom Pires

These limitations reveal what different actors cared about — profit, piety, danger, power, curiosity, or prestige.

Trade Diasporas and Port-City Worlds

Ports were social laboratories, not just loading points for cargo.

KEY POINTS

- **Merchants settled far from home —** *Persian, Arab, Jewish, Indian and later Chinese traders built commercial settlements abroad.*
- **Diasporic communities enabled trust and continuity —** *They provided information, language mediation, credit and legal support.*
- **Ports became multilingual and multi-religious spaces —** *Different communities coexisted, competed, and collaborated within the same city.*
- **Exchange depended on coexistence and negotiation —** *Durable patterns of cosmopolitan life took shape around commerce.*

KEY IDEA

Trade diasporas lowered the costs of trust — identity itself was negotiated in these port cities.

Islam as a Framework of Exchange

Religion could function not just as belief, but as commercial infrastructure.

KEY POINTS

- **Shared legal and ethical norms aided trade —** *Islamic law, taxation and custom gave merchants a recognizable framework over enormous distances.*

- **Muslim merchant networks linked Africa, Arabia, India, Southeast Asia, and China —** *A merchant from Cairo, Aden, Cambay or Malacca entered a familiar legal environment.*

- **Pilgrimage reinforced commercial ties —** *The hajj created regular, large-scale movement of people and goods.*

- **Religion and commerce were mutually reinforcing —** *Shared expectations stabilised trust across vast distances.*

CAREFUL FRAMING

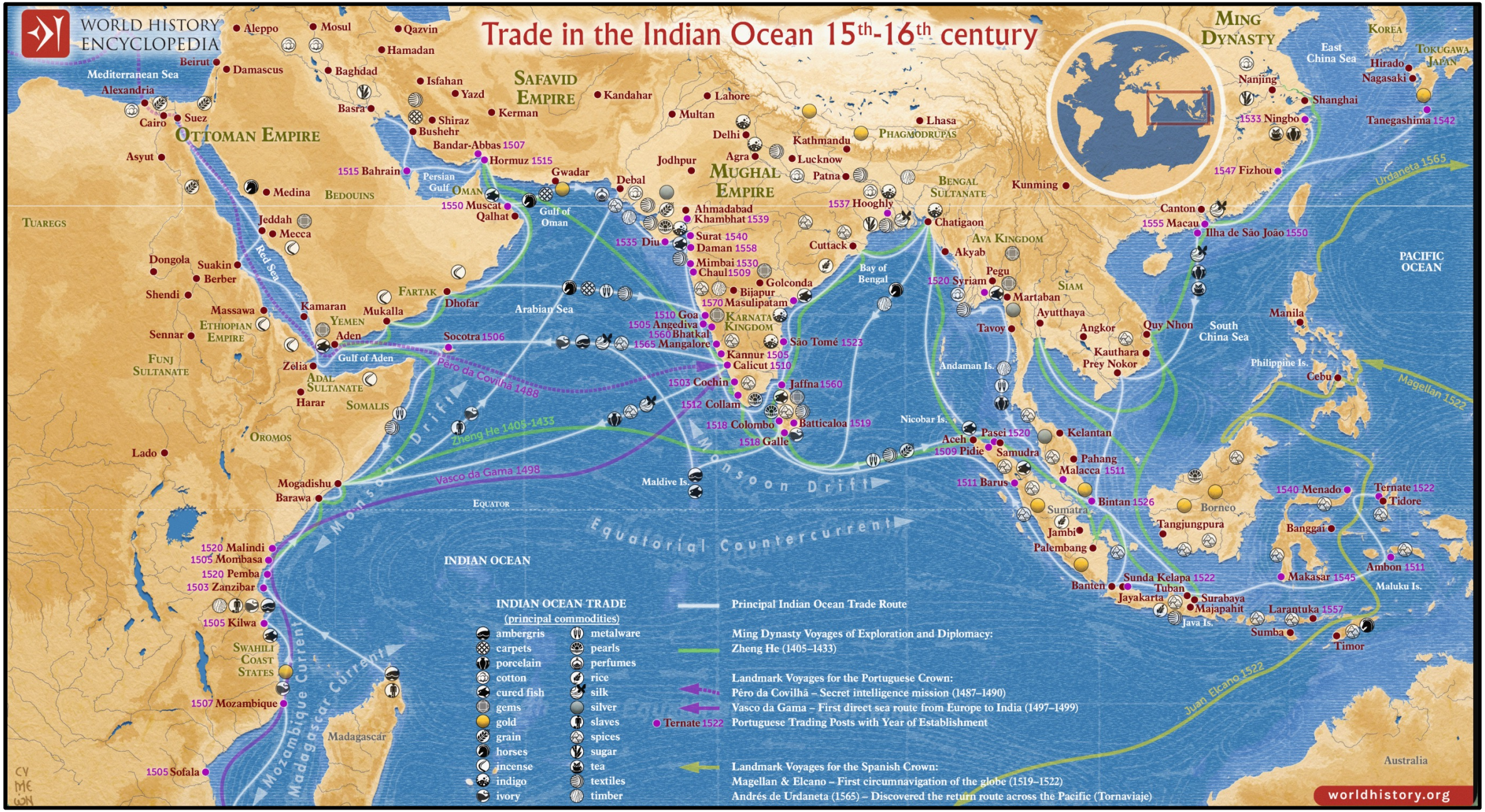
Bernstein is not saying only Muslims traded — rather, Islamic frameworks made long-distance interaction easier for everyone.

PART TWO

Why India Becomes Central

Geography alone is not enough to explain India's role in the system.

- **Geographically between the Gulf and China** — *India sits at the midpoint of the routes linking western and eastern Asia.*
- **Economically vital as producer and intermediary** — *Highly desired goods and major commercial communities, not just a waypoint.*
- **Home to major ports and merchant communities** — *Ports connected inland production to oceanic circulation.*
- **Key transmitter of religion and commercial culture** — *Coastal societies helped carry Islam and trade practices into Southeast Asia.*

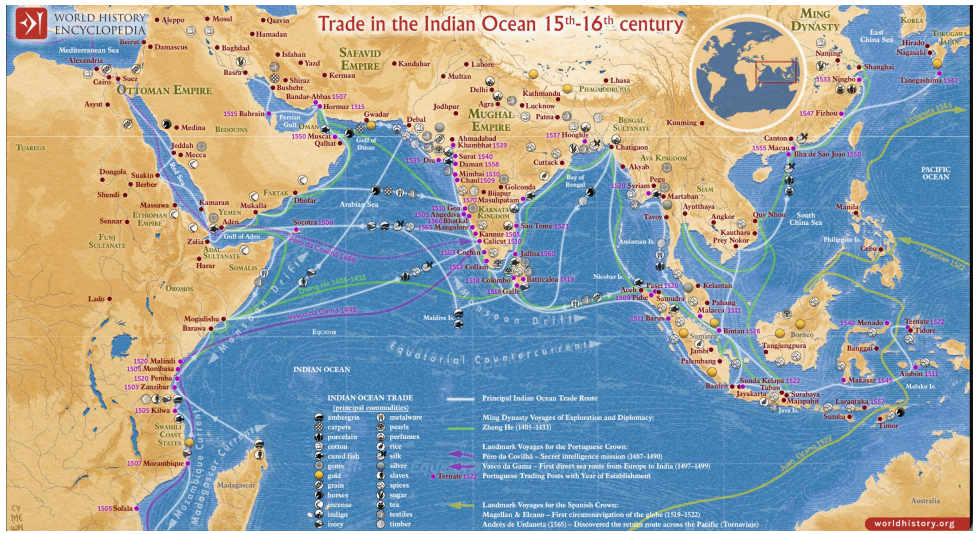

WORLD HISTORY ENCYCLOPEDIA
Trade in the Indian Ocean 15th-16th century
Aleppo
Mosul
Qazvin
Hamadan
Beirut
Damascus
Baghdad
Mediterranean Sea
Alexandria
Isfahan
Yazd
Safavid Empire
Kandahar
Lahore
Basra
Kerman
Multan
Cairo
Suez
Shiraz
Bushehr
Ottoman Empire
Delhi
Lhasa
Kathmandu
Phagmodrupas
Bandar-Abbas 1507
Asyut
Hormuz 1515
Agra
Lucknow
Jodhpur
Mughal Empire
1515 Bahrain
Persian Gulf
Gwadar
Patna
Debal
Bengal Sultanate
Kunming
Medina
Bedouins
Oman
1550 Muscat
Qalhat
Gulf of Oman
1537 Hooghly
Tuaregs
Jeddah
Mecca
Ahmadabad
Khambhat 1539
Chatigaon
Red Sea
Surat 1540
1535 Diu
Daman 1558
Ava Kingdom
Cuttack
Dongola
Suakin
Berber
Mimbai 1530
Chaul 1509
Akyab
Pegu
Shendi
Golconda
Bay of Bengal
1520 Syriam
Siam
Fartak
Bijapur
Martaban
Massawa
Dhofar
1570 Masulipatam
Kamaran
Mukalla
Arabian Sea
1510 Goa
Karnata Kingdom
Ayutthaya
Yemen
1505 Angediva
Tavoy
Ethiopian Empire
Sennar
Aden
1560 Bhatkal
Angkor
Quy Nhon
South China Sea
Socotra 1506
1565 Mangalore
São Tomé 1523
Kauthara
Prey Nokor
Funj Sultanate
Gulf of Aden
Kannur 1505
Andaman Is.
Zeila
Calicut 1510
Philippine Is.
Cebu
Adal Sultanate
1503 Cochin
Jaffna 1560
Harar
Somalis
1512 Collam
Nicobar Is.
Oromos
1518 Colombo
Batticaloa 1519
Pasei 1520
Kelantan
Lado
1518 Galle
Aceh
1509 Pidie
Samudra
Pahang
Malacca 1511
Mogadishu
Maldive Is
1511 Barus
Barawa
Bintan 1526
Sumatra
Borneo
Equator
Tangjungpura
Jambi
Palembang
1520 Malindi
1505 Mombasa
1520 Pemba
1503 Zanzibar
Indian Ocean
Banten
Sunda Kelapa 1522
Tuban
Jayakarta
Surabaya
Majapahit
Java Is.
1505 Kilwa
Swahili Coast States
1507 Mozambique
Madagascar
1505 Sofala
Ming Dynasty
East China Sea
Korea
Tokugawa Japan
Hirado
Nagasaki
Nanjing
Shanghai
1533 Ningbo
Tanegashima 1542
1547 Fizhou
Urdaneta 1565
Canton
1555 Macau
Ilha de São João 1550
Pacific Ocean
Manila
Magellan 1522
1540 Menado
Ternate 1522
Tidore
Banggai
Ambon 1511
Makasar 1545
Maluku Is.
Larantuka 1557
Sumba
Timor
Australia
Juan Elcano 1522
Monsoon Drift
Zheng He 1405-1433
Vasco da Gama 1498
Pêro da Covilhã 1488
Equatorial Countercurrent
Mozambique Current
Madagascar Current
INDIAN OCEAN TRADE
(principal commodities)
ambergris
carpets
porcelain
cotton
cured fish
gems
gold
grain
horses
incense
indigo
ivory
metalware
pearls
perfumes
rice
silk
silver
slaves
spices
sugar
tea
textiles
timber
Principal Indian Ocean Trade Route
Ming Dynasty Voyages of Exploration and Diplomacy:
Zheng He (1405–1433)
Landmark Voyages for the Portuguese Crown:
Pêro da Covilhã – Secret intelligence mission (1487–1490)
Vasco da Gama – First direct sea route from Europe to India (1497–1499)
Ternate 1522 Portuguese Trading Posts with Year of Establishment
Landmark Voyages for the Spanish Crown:
Magellan & Elcano – First circumnavigation of the globe (1519–1522)
Andrés de Urdaneta (1565) – Discovered the return route across the Pacific (Tornaviaje)
worldhistory.org

India as the Intermediary of the Indian Ocean

A region can be central not only by producing goods, but by connecting others.

KEY POINTS

- **Bridged western and eastern circuits —** *Ships from the Gulf or Red Sea often reached India before continuing farther east.*
- **Linked the Gulf, East Africa, Southeast Asia, and China —** *Multiple sub-networks converged through Indian ports into one larger system.*
- **Goods often changed hands in Indian ports —** *Cargo was sorted, taxed, repackaged and redirected there.*
- **India was both market and transit zone —** *Not only a place of consumption — also a redistribution center.*



ANALYTICAL POINT

This is one of the most important lessons for students: centrality can come from connecting regions, not just producing goods.

Gujarat and Cambay: Commercial Mastery

Indian trade here was highly organized and technically skilled — not secondary or dependent.

- **Gujarat was a major trading region —** *One of the most commercially sophisticated regions in the Indian Ocean world.*
- **Cambay emerged as a leading port —** *A hub for goods moving toward the Gulf, Red Sea, East Africa and Southeast Asia.*
- **Gujarati merchants were widely admired for commercial skill —** *Even Tome Pires, writing from a Portuguese viewpoint, praised their sophistication and reach.*
- **Cloth, indigo, and western Indian trade fueled larger circuits —** *A local commercial culture operating at genuinely global scale.*

CASE STUDY

Gujarat is an excellent example of how local commercial cultures could compete on a global stage.

Indian Textiles and the Logic of Exchange

If spices were glamorous, cloth was indispensable.

- **Cotton textiles were among India's most important exports —**
Foundational to the trading system, not a secondary commodity.

- **Textiles linked Indian producers to Asian consumers —**
Versatile and desirable across many different markets, not only for elites.

- **Cloth often moved in exchange for spices, silk, and porcelain**
— *A central commodity in large-scale, reciprocal trade.*

- **India helped sustain the material basis of the system —**
Broad, everyday demand gave Indian manufactures wider reach than rare luxury goods.

KEY IDEA

India was central not just symbolically, but structurally — textile production underpinned the whole oceanic economy.

The Malabar Coast and the Pepper Trade

A crop grown in one coastal environment shaped pricing and diplomacy across continents.

KEY POINTS

- **Malabar was a crucial spice zone —** *One of the medieval world's major spice-producing and exporting regions.*
- **Calicut became a major port —** *A hub built substantially around the pepper trade.*
- **Pepper tied India to Chinese, Arab, and later European demand —** *Chinese vessels came for enormous quantities — demand was never only European.*
- **South Indian coasts were deeply integrated into oceanic trade —** *Local ecology shaped shipping, pricing and even imperial ambition abroad.*

DECENTRING EUROPE

Bernstein's point about Chinese demand reminds us that Asian markets were powerful in their own right.

Ibn Battuta's India: Court, Credit, and Connectivity

Mobility in this world was not only commercial — it was intellectual, legal and political too.

- **Delhi Sultanate drew scholars and officials from across the Islamic world —** *India as a hub for talent and ambition, not only trade.*
- **Muhammad Ibn Tughluq's court reveals political volatility —** *Battuta's account shows both extraordinary opportunity and real instability.*
- **Credit, patronage, and office were tied together —** *Court favour often required expensive gifts, financed through cycles of debt.*
- **India was integrated into a larger Muslim ecumene —** *A major center within the wider Islamic intellectual and legal world.*

DIFFERENT ANGLE

Battuta arrives as a legal scholar, not a merchant — a reminder that exchange took many forms.

From Delhi to the Coast

Commercial success depended less on religious identity than on workable institutions.

- **Inland power and maritime trade were connected but distinct —** *Delhi's inland authority differed from the coastal, commercial power of the ports.*
- **Cambay and Calicut linked hinterland and ocean —** *Coastal cities connected inland production to overseas markets.*
- **Coastal prosperity rested on trade-friendly institutions —** *Security, predictable taxation and port efficiency mattered most.*
- **Multiple political systems could support exchange —** *Both Muslim and Hindu rulers sustained prosperous trading environments.*

AVOID RIGID CATEGORIES

This encourages us to look at institutions and incentives, not fixed civilisational labels.

India as a Cultural Conduit

Cultural change often travels through routine commerce, not dramatic events.

- **Muslim traders from India carried Islam eastward —** *Merchants carried religious practice alongside cloth and spices.*
- **Commercial networks preceded political conversion —** *Trade relationships often came first; broader religious change followed.*
- **Intermarriage helped create lasting communities —** *Families formed around merchant settlements sustained change across generations.*
- **Cultural exchange often moved through everyday commerce —** *Routine, repeated contact — not conquest — drove much of the transformation.*

GLOBAL HISTORY LESSON

A crucial reminder: religious and cultural change often happens through households and trade, not just armies.

Malacca, India, and the Shape of the Asian World System

Malacca was not important despite India — it was important largely because of India.

- **Malacca linked India to China and the Spice Islands —** *A major entrepot connecting the western Indian Ocean to Southeast Asia and China.*

- **Indians were among its most important merchant communities —** *Essential to Malacca's function as a global trading hub.*

- **Gujarati and Malabari traders were central to its success —** *Cloth moved east while spices, silk and porcelain moved back west.*

- **Port governance and low duties encouraged exchange —** *Reliable rules and dispute management gave traders reasons to return.*

CLEAREST EVIDENCE

One of the clearest demonstrations in the chapter of India's centrality to the entire system.

SLIDE 19

Why This Matters for Global History

Europe entered an already connected world — it did not create global interconnection from scratch.

- **Premodern globalisation was real and complex —** *Long before European dominance, exchange was already sophisticated and interconnected.*
- **Europe entered an already connected world —** *A later participant in existing networks, not their creator.*
- **India was central to both commerce and cultural transfer —** *Geographically, economically, institutionally and culturally central all at once.*
- **Oceanic exchange shaped later imperial and global systems —** *Later trade empires built upon, disrupted and partly appropriated existing structures.*

SLIDE 20

Conclusion

- **The Indian Ocean was a major arena of ‘peaceful’ global exchange —** *Its operation depended on winds, ports, merchants, institutions and shared norms.*
- **Trade carried goods, institutions, and beliefs —** *Exchange was never only economic.*
- **India was a pivot of Afro-Eurasian connectivity —** *A producer, intermediary, market, maritime zone, and cultural transmitter, all at once.*
- **Commercial exchange was also cultural exchange —** *To study the history of trade is to study the making of connected worlds.*

https://youtu.be/a6XtBLDmPA0?si=OTe_NSM-_lWO04QM